landscape of the country. And what it shows is the dominance of the universities from the north and south in the top ranks. Among the top 20 government general universities, eight are from the north and 10 from the south, increasing their combined total to 18 from 16 last year. In contrast, the dominance is less pronounced among the top 20 private general universities, with 11 from the north and five from the south, reducing their combined total from 18 last year to 16 now. Interestingly, Symbiosis International (Deemed University) topped the private general universities list, participating in the survey for the first time. In the medical universities rankings, four of the top 10 are from the north, two less than last year, while three are from the south, one more than last year. In 2022, southern universities made up 50 per cent of the top 10 rankings.

The distribution is more even among the top 20 technical universities, with eight from the north, four from the east, three each from the west and south, and two from central India. Similarly, the nine participating law universities are spread evenly across the country's geography, with three in the south, two in the east, two in central India, and one each in the west and north.

One encouraging outcome of this year's survey is the slightly reduced gap in the quality of education between government and private general universities. Out of a total score of 2,000, the top 10 government general universities scored between 1,805 and 1,532, while private universities scored between 1,651 and 1,367, an improvement from last year's range of 1,609 to 1,375. However, the disparity between government and private universities in the medical and technical streams continues to be a cause for concern.

With more than 40 per cent of the country's universities in the private sector, it is essential to bridge these gaps quickly. Our rankings aim to alert policymakers on disparities in the quality of education and to inspire competition among universities, catalysing improvement and a more even distribution of quality across institutions. At the same time, they help students choose the right courses at the right universities. Indian students have shown great success internationally, and they deserve better higher educational institutions at home. Not only will this prevent brain drain from our country, but it will also allow students from other countries seek an education in our universities, making them truly global institutions. It's well worth aspiring for and working towards this mission. ■



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CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

THE EXPANDING UNIVERSE

More than 360 new universities have come up in the past decade; 70 set up in the past one year

YEAR	NO. OF UNIVERSITIES
2015-16	799
2016-17	864
2017-18	903
2018-19	993
2019-20	1,043
2021-22	1,047
2023	1,093
2024	1,163